

The “*i* before *e* except after *c*” rule

THE “*I* BEFORE *E* EXCEPT AFTER *C*” RULE IS USED TO REMEMBER SPELLINGS CONTAINING *IE* OR *EI*.

This rule has been used for more than 150 years, and it works in the majority of cases. There are, however, many exceptions to the rule, and it’s best to learn these and to be aware of them.

The rhyme

A useful rhyme was created to help people remember the “*i* before *e*” rule. Originally, it consisted of only two lines, but it has been expanded over the years to include some exceptions to the rule.

The start of the rhyme means that *i* usually comes before *e* in words that contain an “ee” sound, such as *thief*.

*I before e,
Except after c
When the sound is “ee”
Or when sounded as “ay,”
As in neighbor and weigh,
But leisure and seize
Do as they please.*

However, when the “ee” sound comes after the letter *c*, the *e* goes before the *i*, as in *receive*.

The *e* also goes first when the sound in the word is “ay,” as in *eight*.

The end of the rhyme notes that there are some words that don’t follow any particular rule.

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• There are **no *cein*** words in the English language. If a *c* is followed by an *ie/ei* combination then an *n*, the spelling should **always be *ie***, as in ***science***.

REAL WORLD

Loan words

A word that has been borrowed from another language is called a loan word. Many loan words use an *e* before *i* spelling. These words include *geisha* from Japanese, *sheikh* from Arabic, and *rottweiler* from German. Many names borrowed from foreign languages are also spelled with the *e* first, such as *Keith*, *Heidi*, *Neil*, and *Sheila*.



• If in **doubt**, always use a **dictionary** to confirm whether a word uses *ie* or *ei*.